the former to patrol the border better. Moreover, with NATO troops withdrawing from active combat roles, the nature of engagement was changing from the Taliban fighting an 'occupying force' to the Afghan army fighting 'anti-state insurgents'.

India actively reached out to Moscow in April 2014 to discuss the supply of heavy weaponry to Afghanistan for which New Delhi could pay for.[133] India's traditional ally who gave the partisans muscular agency in the 1990s, Russia favoured the deal for security and economic reasons. From a security perspective a strong Afghan army would help keeping the Taliban away from the Central Asian Republics whereas money generated from arms sales would bolster, in whatever little way, Moscow's defence production. Indo-Russian cooperation, however, was contingent on continued Western military presence that entailed Karzai signing the BSA with the US. Both New Delhi and Moscow were convinced about the futility of arming the ANSF without a comprehensive security infrastructure that only the US and the NATO could provide. A *Times of India* editorial on this issue reflected the dominance of partisan narratives:

> Short of putting military boots on the ground, New Delhi shouldn't be niggardly in helping in this regard. Karzai's wish list includes, reportedly, hand-me-down howitzers, helicopters and bridge-laying equipment. While it features nothing that would break New Delhi's bank, fulfilling the wish list carries the risk of offending Pakistan. On that score, however, New Delhi can go all out to assuage Islamabad's anxieties. Once we are willing to move beyond policies designed to cut off one's own nose in order to spite one's neighbour, it ought to be abundantly clear that Afghan security is as much, or even more, in Pakistan's interest as it is in India's.[134]

The conciliators argued that there is no reason why India should not supply weapons to Afghanistan. After all they were both sovereign nations and strategic partners. Nonetheless, unlike the partisans, the conciliators were reluctant to proactively seek a defence partnership with Kabul. This reservation had two aspects. Firstly, the supply of weapons to Kabul would indeed antagonise Pakistan, and India should not be seen as supporting territorial revisionism. Secondly, an arms transfer could have a destabilising effect if the weapons fall into the wrong hands, those being, the anti-government elements. This was compounded by the fact that India and its regional allies including Russia and Iran could not offer the security umbrella in Afghanistan that NATO did. Lack of confidence in the ANSF to hold ground under military pressure and little